

Word family: **tell / tells / told / telling / teller**

Base word: tell

Third-person singular: tells

Past tense: told

Past participle: told

-ing form: telling

Related forms: teller, telling

Useful constructions/extensions: tell someone something, tell someone about something, tell someone to do something, tell someone not to do something, tell a story, tell the truth, tell a lie, tell the difference, tell apart, tell from, you can tell, time will tell, tell on someone, telling detail, bank teller

Part of speech: mainly verb (動詞) / related noun and adjective forms (相關名詞及形容詞)

Your passage contains:

> “Whenever I visit, she insists on making tea and cutting fruit for everyone, even when we **tell** her to rest.”

Here, **tell** means:

to instruct, advise, or strongly say to someone that they should do something.

Meaning in this passage

In:

> **tell her to rest**

tell means:

to say directly to someone that they should perform a particular action.

The family is effectively saying:

> “You should rest.”

or:

> “Please sit down and rest.”

So the structure is:

> **tell + person + to + verb**

****Meaning:**** To instruct or direct someone to do something.

****繁體中文：**** 叫 / 吩咐 / 告訴某人去做某事；這裡指家人叫外婆休息

****中文翻譯：****

> “Even when we tell her to rest.”

「就算我們叫她休息也一樣。」

So:

****tell someone to do something = 叫 / 吩咐某人做某事****

This is the exact passage meaning.

1. ****tell + person + to + verb (叫某人做某事) — 叫；吩咐；指示****

This is the exact construction used in your passage.

****Meaning:**** To instruct, direct, or strongly advise someone to perform an action.

Practice 1 — Original

> “We ****tell her to rest****.”

「我們叫她休息。」

Practice 2

> “The doctor ****told him to exercise**** more.”

「醫生叫他多做運動。」

Practice 3

> “My manager ****told me to arrive**** early.”

「經理叫我提早到。」

****tell someone to do = 直接對某人表示應該 / 必須進行某項行動****

2. **tell + person + not to + verb (叫某人不要做) — 叫.....不要；吩咐不要**

Practice 4

> “She **told me not to worry**.”

「她**叫我不擔心**。」

Practice 5

> “The teacher **told us not to talk**.”

「老師**叫我們不要說話**。」

tell someone not to do = 指示 / 要求某人不要進行某項行動

3. **tell someone something (告訴某人某事) — 告訴；把資訊說給.....知道**

A major core meaning.

Practice 6

> “She **told me the news**.”

「她**把消息告訴我**。」

Practice 7

> “Can you **tell me your name**?”

「你可以**告訴我你的名字**嗎？」

tell someone something = 把資訊、事實或內容直接傳達給某人

4. **tell someone that + clause (告訴某人.....) — 告知；說明**

Practice 8

> “She **told me that** she was tired.”

「她**告訴我她很累**。」

Practice 9

> “They told us that the meeting had been cancelled.”

「他們**告訴我們會議已經取消**。」

tell someone that... = 把一個完整事實 / 消息傳達給某人

5. **tell someone about something (告訴某人關於.....) — 講述；告知**

Practice 10

> “She **told me about** her childhood.”

「她**跟我說了她童年的事情**。」

Practice 11

> “Let me **tell you about** the project.”

「讓我**告訴你這個項目的情況**。」

tell someone about X = 向某人提供關於某人 / 某事的資訊或經歷

6. **tell = say information to someone (告訴) — 告知；說給某人聽**

This is the broad informational core.

Practice 12

> “Please **tell me** what happened.”

「請**告訴我**發生了甚麼事。」

Practice 13

> “Nobody **told us**.”

「沒有人**告訴我們**。」

tell = 把某項資訊傳遞給特定的人

A key feature is that **tell** normally wants a listener/recipient:

> tell **me**

> tell **her**

> tell **them**

7. **tell** = recount a story/event (講述) — 講 ; 講述

A major narrative sense.

Practice 14

> “She **told us a story** about her childhood.”

「她給我們**講了一個關於童年的故事**。」

Practice 15

> “He **told the story** very well.”

「他把那個故事**講得很好**。」

tell a story = 按一定次序講述一系列事件 / 經歷

8. **tell a story** (講故事) — 講述故事

Practice 16

> “My grandmother used to **tell me stories**.”

「我外婆以前常常**講故事給我聽**。」

Practice 17

> “The film **tells the story of** a family.”

「這部電影**講述了一個家庭的故事**。」

tell the story of = 描述 / 敘述某人、某件事或一系列事件的發展

The subject does not have to be a person:

> a book tells a story

> a film tells a story.

9. **tell = communicate through a story/image/data (表達 / 呈現) — 說明 ; 反映**

A figurative extension.

Practice 18

> “The photographs **tell a powerful story**.”

「這些相片**呈現出一個很有力量的故事**。」

Practice 19

> “The numbers **tell a different story**.”

「這些數字**反映出另一種情況**。」

tell a story = 資料、圖像、證據等共同呈現出某種情況 / 訊息

10. **tell the truth (說實話) — 說真話**

A major fixed collocation.

Practice 20

> “Please **tell the truth**.”

「請**說實話**。」

Practice 21

> “She always **tells the truth**.”

「她總是**說真話**。」

tell the truth = 說出與事實相符的內容

11. **tell a lie (說謊) — 說謊 ; 講假話**

The opposite collocation.

Practice 22

> “He **told a lie**.”

「他**說了謊**。」

Practice 23

> “Don’t **tell lies**.”

「不要**說謊**。」

tell a lie = 故意說出自己知道並不真實的內容

Important collocation:

>  tell a lie

not normally:

>  say a lie

12. **tell the difference (分辨差異) — 分辨 ; 看出不同**

A major separate sense.

Meaning: To recognize that two or more things are different.

Practice 24

> “Can you **tell the difference** between the two versions?”

「你能**分辨出**兩個版本的不同嗎？」

Practice 25

> “I can hardly **tell the difference**.”

「我幾乎**分辨不出差別**。」

tell the difference = 辨認兩個 / 多個事物之間的差異

This is genuinely different from “give information.”

13. **tell A from B (分辨 A 和 B) — 區分 ; 辨認**

Practice 26

> “Can you **tell real gold from fake gold**?”

「你能**分辨真金和假金**嗎？」

Practice 27

> “I can’t **tell one twin from the other**.”

「我**分不出這對雙胞胎誰是誰**。」

tell A from B = 看出 A 與 B 的不同並正確辨認

14. **tell apart (分辨開來) — 分得出 ; 區別**

A common phrasal extension closely tied to the distinction sense.

Practice 28

> “The two brothers are difficult to **tell apart**.”

「兩兄弟很難**分辨**。」

Practice 29

> “I can’t **tell the two designs apart**.”

「我**分不出**兩個設計。」

tell apart = 辨認兩個很相似的人 / 物 , 知道哪個是哪個

15. **tell = recognize / perceive from signs (看得出；判斷得出) — 看出；察覺**

A major figurative sense.

Practice 30

> “I could **tell** that she was tired.”

「我**看得出**她累了。」

Practice 31

> “You can **tell** he is nervous.”

「你**看得出**他很緊張。」

tell = 根據表情、聲音、行為或其他跡象判斷某件事

Here **tell** means neither “say” nor “instruct.”

16. **can tell that... (看得出.....) — 察覺；判斷得出**

Practice 32

> “I could **tell that** my grandmother was tired.”

「我**看得出**外婆累了。」

Practice 33

> “You can tell that she cares about everyone.”

「你**可以看得出**她很關心大家。」

can tell that = 從已有跡象推斷 / 察覺某個事實

17. **tell from + evidence/appearance (從.....看出) — 從.....判斷**

Practice 34

> “I could **tell from her voice** that she was tired.”

「我**從她的聲音聽得出**她累了。」

Practice 35

> “You can **tell from his face** that he is worried.”

「你**從他的表情看得出**他很擔心。」

tell from X = 根據某個可觀察跡象作出判斷

Chinese changes naturally according to the sense:

* 看得出

* 聽得出

* 判斷得出

18. **hard/impossible to tell (難以判斷) — 很難說 ; 難以確定**

A major expression.

Practice 36

> “It’s **hard to tell** whether she is tired.”

「很難**判斷**她是否累了。」

Practice 37

> “It is **impossible to tell** what will happen.”

「根本**無法判斷**會發生甚麼。」

hard to tell = 根據目前資訊很難知道 / 確定答案

19. **Who can tell? (誰知道呢 ?) — 誰說得準 ? **

A conversational extension.

Practice 38

> “Will the plan work? **Who can tell?**”

「計劃會成功嗎？**誰知道呢？**」

Practice 39

> “What will happen next? Who can tell?”

「之後會發生甚麼？**誰說得準呢？**」

Who can tell? = 沒有人能確定 / 預測答案

20. **there's no telling... (無法知道 / 預測) — 說不準；無法預料**

A major fixed expression.

Practice 40

> “There's **no telling** what might happen.”

「根本**無法預料**會發生甚麼。」

Practice 41

> “There's no telling how long the process will take.”

「這個過程會花多久，**誰也說不準**。」

there's no telling = 沒有辦法可靠地知道 / 預測某件事

21. **time will tell (時間會證明) — 日後自有分曉**

A major idiom.

Practice 42

> “Will the decision work? **Time will tell**.”

「這個決定是否有效？**日後自有分曉**。」

Practice 43

> “Only time will tell whether the change is permanent.”

「這個改變是否持久，**只有時間能證明**。」

time will tell = 現在無法確定答案，但未來的發展會顯示真相 / 結果

22. **tell = reveal / show information (顯示；透露) — 透露；顯示**

An important extension where the subject may be an object, sign, or evidence.

Practice 44

> “The data **tells us** that demand is increasing.”

「數據**告訴 / 顯示我們**需求正在增加。」

Practice 45

> “Her expression **told me** everything I needed to know.”

「她的表情已經**告訴我 / 透露了**我需要知道的一切。」

tell = 某種證據、跡象或資料傳達 / 顯示資訊

23. **tell its own story (本身已說明一切) — 不言自明；自己說明情況**

Practice 46

> “The empty shelves **tell their own story**.”

「空空的貨架已經**說明了情況 / 不言自明**。」

Practice 47

> “The photographs tell their own story.”

「這些照片本身已經**把事情說明得很清楚**。」

tell its own story = 不需額外解釋，某個現象 / 證據本身已足以顯示情況

24. **tell = have an effect / become noticeable (顯出影響) — 顯出效果；產生明顯影響**

A less obvious but established sense.

Practice 48

> “The years were beginning to ****tell**** on him.”

「歲月開始在他身上****顯出影響****。」

Practice 49

> “The pressure eventually began to tell.”

「壓力最後開始****顯出影響 / 造成明顯後果****。」

****tell = 某種長期因素開始產生可觀察到的影響****

This often occurs in:

> begin to tell

or:

> tell on someone.

25. ****tell on someone = affect negatively (對.....造成影響) — 損害 ; 開始吃不消****

One established meaning of ****tell on****.

Practice 50

> “The long hours began to ****tell on**** her health.”

「長工時開始****損害她的健康****。」

Practice 51

> “Lack of sleep was telling on him.”

「睡眠不足開始令他****吃不消 / 身體受到影響****。」

****tell on someone/something = 對某人 / 某物逐漸造成可見、通常負面的影響****

26. **tell on someone = report their wrongdoing (告發 / 打小報告) — 告狀 ; 告發**

A completely separate phrasal meaning.

Practice 52

> “The child threatened to **tell on** his brother.”

「那孩子威脅要向大人**告哥哥 / 弟弟的狀**。」

Practice 53

> “Don’t tell on me!”

「不要**告我的狀**！」

tell on someone = 把某人的不當行為告訴老師、家長或其他有權力的人

Especially common in children’s English.

27. **tell = order/command (命令) — 命令 ; 吩咐**

A stronger version of the passage construction.

Practice 54

> “I’m **telling you to stop**.”

「我是在**叫你停下來 / 命令你停止**。」

Practice 55

> “He doesn’t like being **told what to do**.”

「他不喜歡別人**告訴他應該怎樣做 / 指揮他**。」

tell someone to do = 根據語氣和關係，可從普通指示到較強的命令

So **tell** itself does not always specify how forceful the instruction is.

28. **be told to do (被吩咐 / 要求) — 被叫去做**

Practice 56

> “I was **told to wait** outside.”

「我被**叫在外面等**。」

Practice 57

> “Employees were told to arrive early.”

「員工被**要求提早到達**。」

be told to do = 收到某人給出的指示 / 命令去做某事

29. **tell someone where/when/how/what (告訴某人資訊) — 告訴 ; 說明**

A very important grammatical pattern.

Practice 58

> “Can you **tell me where** the meeting room is?”

「你可以**告訴我會議室在哪裡**嗎？」

Practice 59

> “Tell me **what happened**.”

「**告訴我發生了甚麼事**。」

tell someone + question word clause = 向某人提供地點、時間、方法、原因等資訊

30. **tell someone how to do something (告訴某人怎樣做) — 教 / 說明方法**

Practice 60

> “She **told me how to make** the tea.”

「她**告訴我怎樣泡茶**。」

Practice 61

> “Can you tell me how to use this?”

「你可以**告訴我這個怎樣用**嗎？」

tell someone how to do = 向某人說明進行某項工作的方式 / 步驟

Depending on context, Chinese may naturally be:

> 告訴

or:

> 教.

31. **tell someone where to go / what to do (指示) — 指示；告訴應怎樣做**

Practice 62

> “The receptionist **told us where to wait**.”

「接待員**告訴我們應在哪裡等**。」

Practice 63

> “Nobody told me what to do.”

「沒有人**告訴我應該怎樣做**。」

tell someone + wh-word + to-infinitive = 給某人具體行動 / 選擇指示

32. **tell yourself (告訴自己 / 提醒自己) — 心裡告訴自己**

A common reflective use.

Practice 64

> “I **told myself** to stay calm.”

「我**告訴自己 / 提醒自己**要保持冷靜。」

Practice 65

> “She kept telling herself that everything would be fine.”

「她不停**對自己說**一切都會沒事。」

tell yourself = 在心裡向自己重複某個想法、指示或安慰

33. **tell someone off (責罵) — 責罵 ; 訓斥**

A major phrasal extension.

Practice 66

> “The teacher **told him off** for being rude.”

「老師因他無禮而**責罵了他**。」

Practice 67

> “She was told off for arriving late.”

「她因遲到而被**訓斥**。」

tell someone off = 嚴厲批評 / 責罵某人做錯的事情

Informal/common.

34. **tell = know with certainty (知道 / 確定) — 確定 ; 知道**

A useful conversational sense, closely tied to “recognize.”

Practice 68

> “I can’t **tell** whether he is serious.”

「我**無法確定**他是不是認真的。」

Practice 69

> “Can you **tell** which answer is correct?”

「你能**判斷出**哪個答案正確嗎？」

****tell = 根據資訊辨認 / 確定某件事情****

35. ****telling = revealing/significant (能說明問題的) — 很能說明問題的 ; 透露真相的****

A major related adjective.

Practice 70

> “Her silence was ****telling****.”

「她的沉默****很能說明問題****。」

Practice 71

> “One particularly ****telling detail**** was missing.”

「有一個特別****能反映真相的細節****不見了。」

****telling = 能夠強烈透露真實情況、具有明顯證明力的****

This is not simply the -ing form of the verb.

36. ****telling detail/sign (很能說明問題的細節 / 跡象) — 有啟示性的 ; 很有說服力的****

Practice 72

> “The most ****telling sign**** was her expression.”

「最****能說明情況的跡象****是她的表情。」

Practice 73

> “The figures provide a telling example of the problem.”

「這些數字提供了一個****很能說明問題的例子****。」

****telling = 能讓人從中清楚看出更深層真相 / 情況的****

37. ****teller = person who tells/counts in certain roles (講述者 / 點票者等) — 特定職務的人****

A related person noun with several lexicalized uses.

One modern common use is:

> **bank teller**

38. **bank teller (銀行櫃員) — 銀行櫃台職員**

Practice 74

> “The **bank teller** helped me with the deposit.”

「**銀行櫃員**幫我處理存款。」

Practice 75

> “She works as a teller at a bank.”

「她在銀行擔任**櫃員**。」

bank teller = 在銀行櫃台處理存款、提款等客戶交易的職員

This is a lexicalized family extension and not another meaning of the verb **tell** itself.

39. **storyteller (說故事的人) — 故事講述者；善於講故事的人**

A useful compound family extension.

Practice 76

> “My grandmother is a wonderful **storyteller**.”

「我外婆很會**講故事**。」

Practice 77

> “He is known as a gifted storyteller.”

「他以善於**說故事**而聞名。」

storyteller = 擅長 / 負責講述故事的人

40. **fortune-teller (算命者) — 算命師**

Another common lexicalized compound.

Practice 78

> “She visited a **fortune-teller**.”

「她去見了一位**算命師**。」

Practice 79

> “The fortune-teller claimed to predict the future.”

「那位**算命師**聲稱能預測未來。」

fortune-teller = 聲稱能預測人的未來 / 命運的人

A useful family compound, but not a core meaning of bare **tell**.

Important distinction: **tell vs say**

This is the most important learner contrast.

tell

usually takes the person receiving the information directly:

> tell **me** the answer

> tell **her** the truth

say

usually focuses on the words/content:

> say “hello”

> say that you are tired

Compare:

>  “She **told me** she was tired.”

>  “She **said** she was tired.”

But:

>  “She said me she was tired.”

And normally:

>  “She told she was tired.”

without specifying the listener.

So:

tell + person

say + content

is a very useful default rule.

Important distinction: **tell vs speak**

tell

= communicate particular information or instructions.

speak

= produce speech / communicate verbally, often focusing on ability or act of speaking.

> “Tell me what happened.”

= 把事情告訴我。

> “Can you speak English?”

= 你會說英語嗎？

Not interchangeable.

Important distinction: ****tell vs talk****

****talk****

= have a conversation/discussion.

****tell****

= transmit specific information.

> “We talked for an hour.”

= 我們談了一小時。

> “She told me the reason.”

= 她告訴我原因。

****Talk**** is interactive; ****tell**** often has information flowing from speaker to listener.

Important distinction: ****tell vs ask****

****tell someone to do****

= give an instruction.

****ask someone to do****

= make a request.

Compare:

> “I told him to sit down.”

= 我叫他坐下。

> “I asked him to sit down.”

= 我請他坐下。

****Tell**** generally sounds more directive.

Important distinction: ****tell vs order****

****tell****

can range from ordinary instruction to command.

****order****

explicitly means:

> give an authoritative command.

> “The doctor told him to rest.”

natural and not necessarily authoritarian.

> “The officer ordered him to stop.”

much stronger.

Important distinction: ****tell vs advise****

****advise someone to do****

= recommend based on judgment/expertise.

****tell someone to do****

= directly instruct them.

In your passage:

> “we tell her to rest”

could pragmatically function as advice, but grammatically ****tell**** is stronger/directer than ****advise****.

Important distinction: ****tell vs inform****

****tell****

= everyday and flexible.

inform

= more formal and specifically about providing information.

> “Tell me if anything changes.”

everyday.

> “Please inform me of any changes.”

formal.

Inform does not normally carry the “instruct someone to do” sense that **tell** has.

Important distinction: **tell a story vs say a story**

Standard English:

>  **tell a story**

not normally:

>  **say a story**

Similarly:

* tell a joke

* tell the truth

* tell a lie

These are important collocations.

Important distinction: **tell a joke vs say something funny**

tell a joke

= deliberately recount a joke.

say something funny

= make a funny remark.

Different action.

Important distinction: ****tell the truth vs speak the truth****

Both are valid.

****tell the truth****

is the everyday default.

****speak the truth****

sounds more formal, solemn, or rhetorical.

Important distinction: ****tell the difference vs see the difference****

Both can mean detect a difference.

****tell the difference****

emphasizes:

> ability to distinguish correctly.

****see the difference****

often means:

> visually notice/understand that a difference exists.

You can sometimes tell the difference using:

* smell;

* sound;

* taste;

not just sight.

So ****tell**** is broader.

Important distinction: **tell from vs judge from**

tell from

= recognize/determine from evidence, everyday.

judge from

= form an assessment based on evidence.

> “I could tell from her voice that she was tired.”

very natural.

Important distinction: **tell vs know**

know

= possess knowledge.

tell

in:

> “I can’t tell”

means:

> I cannot determine the answer from the available evidence.

Compare:

> “I don’t know.”

= I lack the information.

> “I can’t tell.”

= the evidence is insufficient for me to determine it.

Subtle but useful.

Important distinction: **can tell vs can see**

can see

may be literal visual perception or figurative understanding.

can tell

means:

> infer/recognize from signs.

> “I can tell you’re tired.”

does not mean the speaker literally sees tiredness as an object.

Important distinction: **tell on someone — two meanings**

This is a major ambiguity.

Report wrongdoing:

> “He told on his brother.”

= 他告弟弟 / 哥哥的狀。

Affect negatively:

> “The stress is telling on him.”

= 壓力開始對他造成明顯負面影響。

These are genuinely different.

Important distinction: **telling — verb form vs adjective**

Verb form:

> “She is telling a story.”

= 正在講故事。

Adjective:

> “That is a telling detail.”

= 那是一個很能說明問題的細節。

The adjective has developed its own lexical meaning:

> revealing / significant.

Important distinction: **teller vs storyteller**

teller

alone most commonly suggests a bank employee in modern everyday English.

storyteller

= person who tells stories.

The meaning of the compound is more transparent.

Family-extension sweep

The practical **tell** family is exceptionally rich in information, instruction, narration, recognition, and inference:

- * **tell someone to do** = 叫 / 吩咐某人做
- * **tell someone not to do** = 叫某人不要做
- * **tell someone something** = 告訴某人某事
- * **tell someone that...** = 告訴某人.....
- * **tell someone about** = 告訴某人關於.....
- * **tell a story** = 講故事
- * **tell the story of** = 講述.....
- * **tell a different story** = 顯示另一種情況
- * **tell the truth** = 說實話
- * **tell a lie** = 說謊
- * **tell the difference** = 分辨差異
- * **tell A from B** = 分辨 A 與 B
- * **tell apart** = 區分

* **can tell** = 看得出 / 判斷得出
 * **tell from** = 從.....看出 / 聽出
 * **hard to tell** = 很難判斷
 * **there's no telling** = 無法預料
 * **time will tell** = 日後自有分曉
 * **tell — reveal** = 顯示 / 透露
 * **tell its own story** = 本身已說明情況
 * **tell — have an effect** = 顯出影響
 * **tell on — affect** = 對.....造成負面影響
 * **tell on — report wrongdoing** = 告狀 / 告發
 * **be told to do** = 被要求 / 吩咐做
 * **tell someone how/where/what** = 告訴某人方法 / 資訊
 * **tell yourself** = 告訴 / 提醒自己
 * **tell off** = 責罵
 * **telling — revealing** = 很能說明問題的
 * **bank teller** = 銀行櫃員
 * **storyteller** = 故事講述者
 * **fortune-teller** = 算命師

The main semantic branches are:

- > **give information**
- > **instruct/direct someone**
- > **narrate/recount**
- > **distinguish**
- > **infer/recognize from evidence**
- > **reveal/show**
- > **produce noticeable effects**

plus several important fixed constructions.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
-----	-----
tell someone to do	直接指示 / 要求某人進行某項行動
tell someone not to do	指示 / 要求某人不要進行某項行動
tell someone something	把特定資訊、事實或內容傳達給某人

tell someone that...	把一個完整事實 / 消息直接告知某人	
tell someone about	向某人提供關於某人 / 某事的資訊或經歷	
tell a story	按一定次序講述一系列事件 / 經歷	
tell a story — figurative	資料、圖片、證據等共同呈現某種情況 / 訊息	
tell the truth	說出與實際事實相符的內容	
tell a lie	故意說出自己知道並不真實的內容	
tell the difference	辨認兩個 / 多個事物之間的不同	
tell A from B	正確分辨 A 和 B，知道哪個是哪個	
tell apart	辨認兩個相似的人 / 物並區分開來	
can tell	根據表情、聲音、行為或證據察覺 / 判斷某事	
tell from	根據特定跡象看出、聽出或判斷出某事	
hard to tell	根據目前資訊很難知道 / 確定答案	
there's no telling	沒有可靠方法知道 / 預測某件事情	
time will tell	現在無法確定，但未來發展最終會顯示結果	
tell — reveal/show	某種證據、資訊或表情顯示 / 透露某個事實	
tell — effect	某個長期因素開始產生可觀察到的影響	
tell on — effect	對某人的健康、表現等逐漸造成明顯負面影響	
tell on — report	把某人的不當行為告訴老師、家長或其他有權人士	
be told to do	收到某人的指示 / 要求去進行某項行動	
tell someone how/where/what	向某人提供做法、位置、內容等具體資訊	
tell yourself	在心裡對自己重複某種指示、想法或安慰	
tell off	嚴厲批評 / 責罵某人的錯誤行為	
telling — adjective	能強烈透露真實情況、很能說明問題的	
bank teller	在銀行櫃台處理客戶交易的職員	
storyteller	擅長 / 負責講述故事的人	
fortune-teller	聲稱能預測未來或命運的人	

For your original passage

> “Whenever I visit, she insists on making tea and cutting fruit for everyone, even when we **tell her to rest**.”

The exact meaning is:

tell someone to do something = 叫 / 吩咐某人做某事

Therefore:

> **tell her to rest**

= **「叫她休息 / 勸她去休息」**

The context makes the interpersonal dynamic very clear:

> grandmother continues serving everyone

→

> family tells her:

> “Please rest.”

→

> she still insists on making tea and cutting fruit.

So ****tell**** here is not:

> tell = 講故事

not:

> tell = 告知資訊

and not:

> tell = 看得出

It is the ****instruction/directive**** meaning.

The most important learner contrasts are:

> ****tell her to rest****

> = 叫她休息

> ****tell me the answer****

> = 告訴我答案

> ****tell me that she is fine****

> = 告訴我她沒事

> ****tell me about your family****

> = 告訴我你的家庭情況

> ****tell a story****

> = 講故事

> ****tell the truth****

> = 說實話

> ****tell a lie****

> = 說謊

> ****tell the difference****

> = 分辨差異

> ****tell A from B****

> = 分辨 A 和 B

> ****I can tell she is tired****

> = 我看得出她累了

> ****I can tell from her voice****

> = 我從她聲音聽得出來

> ****It's hard to tell****

> = 很難判斷

> ****Time will tell****

> = 日後自有分曉

> ****tell on someone****

> = 告某人的狀；另一語境亦可指對某人造成負面影響

> ****telling evidence/detail****

> = 很能說明問題的證據 / 細節

So ****tell**** is much richer than simply:

> ****tell = 告訴****

and in your original passage it specifically means:

****“to directly tell/instruct her that she should stop serving everyone and rest.”****